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Statement of Originality

I confirm that I have fully acknowledged all sources of information and help received and
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Befindlichkeit und Gestimmtheit: States of Being in Composition and Performance

A Contextual Review

Lerne singen, o Seele — Nietzsche

Introduction

This research is situated within contemporary vocal and performance practices. While these frameworks offer rich resources for developing vocal ability and artistic identity, they tend to treat expression as something produced through the voice, rather than examining the voice itself as a site of relational and state-based transformation. The question of how a performer's internal state shapes the relational field between voice, self, and audience remains comparatively underexplored.

State-based approaches to performance have been extensively developed within experimental theatre and dance — particularly in psychophysical training methods that treat internal state as a primary artistic material. Such approaches remain less systematically articulated within vocal and musical practice. This research positions itself within that gap.

The project investigates the relational dimensions of vocal performance and composition along two interconnected axes: the ways in which a singer relates to their own voice as a dynamic and malleable field, and the ways in which this relation extends outward through sound to shape the shared experiential space with an audience. Rather than understanding the voice as a stable instrument conveying pre-formed meaning, this research approaches it as a medium through which states of being are enacted, modulated, and communicated.

Yet these two axes rest on a third and more fundamental question. Access to different states, and the capacity to shape the relational field with an audience, do not by themselves give direction to a practice. A singer may learn to enter many configurations of voice and presence — and still be choosing among them rather than being claimed by any of them. The question of what genuinely needs to be sung — of how inner necessity can be distinguished from habit, technique, or performed conviction — underlies both axes, and gives the practice its orientation and its stakes.

The working title *Befindlichkeit und Gestimmtheit* is drawn from Martin Heidegger's terminology. *Befindlichkeit* refers to the condition in which one always already finds oneself; *Gestimmtheit* names the tonal attunement through which this condition discloses the world. I adopt and extend this distinction in a specifically practice-based direction. *Befindlichkeit*, in this research, concerns the cultivation of a higher-resolution awareness of one's own state — a clearer perception of how one is in a given moment. *Gestimmtheit* names something complementary and dynamic: not a fixed mood, but a capacity for fluid movement through states, a responsiveness that becomes available precisely when one's current state is perceived with clarity. It is this capacity — trainable, developable, available as artistic material — that the practice this research is building toward aims to cultivate.

These terms frame three guiding questions, all three questions of which are approached through the lens of what can be deliberately trained — what practices can be developed, refined, and brought into performance:

- (1) Can a singer relate in different ways to their own voice — and if so, how?
- (2) Can a singer learn to relate in different ways to their audience, transforming the relational field itself into artistic material?
- (3) How does a singer know what they genuinely need to sing — and how can that inner necessity be distinguished from habit, technique, or performed conviction?

Emerging from this investigation is the working hypothesis of a “Method Singer”: a practice-based framework integrating attention, imagination, embodied state-work, and ritualised processes as central components of vocal training and performance. The Method Singer is not defined by a particular sound or style, but by the capacity to enter, sustain, and transform states of being in relation to voice and audience — and by the ability to make the relational field between them an object of deliberate artistic work.

The structure of this paper reflects the contextual nature of the research. It begins with a short autoethnographic sketch outlining the personal and artistic necessity of this inquiry. It then situates the project within relevant artistic and theoretical contexts — practices of internal state transformation, vocal and contemplative traditions, and the historical shaping of performer-audience relations within Western concert frameworks — assessing their relevance and limitations for the present work. The paper concludes with an overview of emerging methodological directions and the areas identified for further development in the subsequent Investigate and Present modules.

Personal Context

Communion may be the most precise word available for what happens — or fails to happen — between a singer and an audience. When I sing alone, I am in communion with myself, and with that part of the world I inhabit through the song. When others are present, this communion either extends to include them, or it does not. I am not one of those singers to whom this comes easily, but I am one to whom it is very important.

All I wanted to be since I was a child was a singer. At the same time, I was repeatedly told not to sing — that I had a bad voice, that it was better if I stopped. I did not stop singing, but I stopped singing in front of and with other people. Over time, this shaped the way my voice exists in relation to others. The act of singing remained, but something in its relational dimension became very constrained.

I had a very different example in my family. My grandfather, a Catholic, would often sing religious songs. I remember feeling something close to envy: he had someone to sing to, who didn't care whether his voice was perfect. Coming from an otherwise atheist environment, this dimension of address — the sense that the voice is directed toward something or someone beyond oneself — was largely absent for me. That absence is, I now recognise, one of the generative pressures behind the first research question: can a singer relate in different ways to their voice, and what does it take to open that relation?

Training my voice with a professional helped. As I began to feel that I could rely on my voice, a certain dread disappeared. But in its place, another question emerged. I started noticing that sometimes I did not seem to touch people very much, and at other times I would move them deeply — sometimes even to tears. I could feel the difference while performing, but I had no way of influencing it. This is where my attention began to shift toward the relational aspect of performance, and toward the second and third research questions: can the relational field with an audience be deliberately shaped, and through what practices?

Voice

Voice has a special place among musical instruments. The voice is of the body, of the mind, and of the state we are in. It is a primary medium of communication, but also of will, and at times of concealment. We even experience our own thoughts in vocal terms, as a voice in the head. An instrument that we say betrays us when it reveals how we actually feel, rather

than how we would like to appear. What is unique about it — both in how it can be trained, and in how it affects those who hear it?

Mladen Dolar's account of the voice is useful here because he approaches it as something that cannot be reduced either to language or to sound (Dolar, 2006). The voice carries meaning, but it also exceeds meaning; it is produced by the body, yet it is never simply a bodily object. Dolar's concept of the voice as remainder helps name the dimension of vocal expression that interests this research: the part of the voice that affects, unsettles, attracts, or repels before it can be fully interpreted. This remainder is precisely what the first research question is reaching toward — the voice not as fixed instrument but as a field that shifts with the state of the one who sings.

The marginalised voice

Paul Zumthor observes that among institutionalised disciplines, there is still no coherent science of the voice (Zumthor, 1990). Such a science, he suggests, would necessarily span multiple domains, from linguistics to anthropology to physiology to acoustics — an indication of how difficult the voice is to locate within a single framework. Mladen Dolar offers perspective on this difficulty in his “A voice and nothing more”: for him, voice carries meaning, but it also exceeds meaning; it is produced by the body, yet it is never simply a bodily object (Dolar, 2006). Dolar's concept of the voice as remainder helps name the dimension of vocal expression that interests this research: the part of the voice that affects, unsettles, attracts, or repels before it can be fully interpreted. This remainder is precisely what the first research question is reaching toward — the voice not as a fixed instrument but as a field that shifts with the state of the one who sings.

At the same time, this orientation remains primarily analytical. The domains Zumthor and Dolar invoke aim to describe and understand the voice, rather than to engage with it as a practice. They offer ways of analysing the voice, but not of working with its relational and experiential dimensions in performance.

This raises the question of why these dimensions have remained so resistant to systematic engagement. One possible answer lies in how the voice has been culturally coded. The relational, affective, and non-conceptual aspects of vocal expression have often been associated with what is traditionally marked as feminine, or as uncultured and socially marginal, and thus positioned at the edges of rational inquiry. The Sirens do not enchant through argument or eloquence, but through the quality of their voices — voices that arise from a source where beauty and danger are inseparable, from outside the ordered realm of

society. In Italo Calvino's *The King Listens* (Calvino, 1988), it is the voice of a woman that disrupts the king's carefully structured world — she resembles a wise fool, whose position outside established order allows her voice to open a different mode of hearing.

Rather than taking these figures at face value (as projections of a “mysterious” or inarticulate and in this case feminine force), it is more productive to read them, following Marie-Louise von Franz's account of fairy tales as expressions of marginalised aspects of the collective psyche (Franz, 1976), as cultural codifications of what has been relegated to the margins. What appears here as dangerous or unknowable is precisely that dimension of the voice which resists abstraction and control. As Hélène Cixous suggests in her call for a writing grounded in the body, such forms of expression are organised not around coherence or mastery but around affirmation — an insistence on presence that exceeds established structures of meaning, and that becomes audible in the voice (Cixous, 1976).

This cultural marginalisation is not incidental to the present research. It helps explain why the very capacities this project is attempting to develop — the singer's fluid, state-responsive relation to their own voice, and the deliberate shaping of the relational field with an audience — have remained resistant to systematic treatment. The absence of frameworks is not accidental; it reflects a long history of treating these capacities as inarticulate, excessive, or beyond training.

The excessive voice

"I work between Cracks, where the Voice starts dancing." — Meredith Monk

James Baldwin's novel *Just Above My Head* opened for this research a way of thinking about music closer to the territory under investigation than most performance theory. In it, music appears not as aesthetic experience or cultural expression, but as a domain of genuine stakes — of cost, spiritual necessity, and transformation (Baldwin, 1980). Through the character of Hall Montana, speaking about his brother Arthur — a gay gospel singer touring the South of USA — music appears not as a chosen activity, but as something that chooses the singer. It is inseparable from the conditions of life and from the tensions that shape it.

This reading of the novel seems amplified if we read what the poet Amiri Baraka articulates in his eulogy for Baldwin — linking voice, revolution, and song to the most basic fact of existence:

For Jimmy was God's black revolutionary mouth. If there is a God, and revolution His righteous natural expression. And elegant song the deepest & most fundamental common-place of being alive.

Amiri Baraka, James Baldwin: His Voice Remembered

Here, voice and song are not expressions of something prior, but ways in which life itself becomes present. Fred Moten (in his *In the Break: The Aesthetics of the Black Radical Tradition*) extends this thinking toward the voice specifically, describing it as a site of excess — something that exceeds formal control and cannot be fully contained within aesthetic structures (Moten, 2003). Writing of Abbey Lincoln's free jazz recording in which she hums and then screams, Moten frames the scream as an event that opens a cascade of questions: "What is the edge of this event? What is the music? What is manhood? What is the feminine? What is the beautiful? What will blackness be?" The voice opens these questions not in order to resolve them conceptually, but to bring them into a field of lived experience where they can be engaged through practice.

For the present research, what Baldwin, Baraka, and Moten share is a conception of the voice as something irreducibly relational and state-dependent — not a neutral instrument but a site where inner necessity and outward relation meet. This is precisely the territory the research questions are pointing toward: the voice as a medium through which the singer's *Befindlichkeit* becomes present to an audience, and through which *Gestimmtheit* — the fluid responsiveness to and movement through states — can become an artistic act. But this tradition also presses on the third research question in a specific way. If the voice is something that chooses the singer — if genuine singing arises from necessity rather than selection — then the question of how a singer knows what they genuinely need to sing is not secondary to technical or relational training. It is foundational to it. This research investigates what practices help a singer develop that quality of being claimed, rather than merely choosing.

The transformative voice

"State of emergency is where I want to be." — Björk, Jóga

Alfred Wolfsohn offers the most direct precedent for what this research is attempting. Working in the aftermath of the Second World War, Wolfsohn found himself haunted by auditory hallucinations — the voices of dying soldiers he had been unable to help. Unable to silence these voices through ordinary means, he turned toward them instead, working with his own voice as a means of metabolising what he had experienced — not by articulating it

discursively, but by giving it form in sound. What emerged was a fundamentally redefined relationship between himself and his voice: the voice as a site of encounter with interior states, a place where extreme conditions could be entered, held, and gradually transformed (Braggins, 2011).

What is significant for this research is not only what Wolfsohn discovered, but what he did with it next. He found that this process was teachable. He established a school, beginning to work with others — demonstrating that the voice could be developed not primarily as an aesthetic instrument, but as a means of accessing and transforming inner states. His work eventually influenced the European avant-garde, reaching practitioners including Peter Brook and Jerzy Grotowski. Roy Hart extended it into a broader pedagogical and performative context.

Yet this work remained at the margins. The dimension of the voice that Wolfsohn had recovered — its capacity to metabolise experience and redefine the relation between self and sound — remained influential but not integrated into mainstream vocal practice. Engaging with Wolfsohn's work is itself an act of creative retrieval: many primary sources are unavailable or difficult to access, and what reaches us arrives largely through the accounts of those he taught and influenced. This research draws on those accounts, and incorporates elements of Wolfsohn's approach into its own emerging practice — not as faithful reconstruction, but as a living inheritance, taken up and extended in a different context.

Wolfsohn's precedent suggests that the first research question — can a singer relate in different ways to their own voice? — has an answer, and that the answer can be taught. But it leaves largely unaddressed the second and third questions: can the relational field with an audience be deliberately shaped from within, through the quality of the singer's presence? And how does a singer know what they genuinely need to sing, as distinct from what they have learned to perform? It is these dimensions — the relational and the question of genuine necessity — that this research adds to Wolfsohn's foundational insight.

State Work

State-work, as understood in this research, is not a search for extraordinary experiences. It is a training in how expression emerges from the state in which one finds oneself — and in how that state can be perceived with clarity, entered deliberately, and made fluid. This is the territory that the three research questions are ultimately about: developing the singer's capacity to inhabit and move through *Befindlichkeit* with enough awareness that *Gestimmtheit* — fluid, responsive attunement — becomes available as artistic material.

Among the contemplative traditions that have developed the most elaborate available maps of inner state, the Indo-Tibetan Mahamudra tradition stands out for its practical precision — and for a quality that is perhaps unexpected in a contemplative tradition: its lightness (Khamtrul, 2014). Mahamudra is known for its simplicity, its adaptability to ordinary life, and its insistence that the practice should be genuinely enjoyable. What distinguishes it methodologically is a highly developed system of step-by-step instructions for directly pointing out the different (what they call) “views” in which the mind can rest. It is, in this sense, reproducible and trainable in a way that many contemplative traditions are not. My own practice of Mahamudra directly informs this research because it trains the first movement of working with *Befindlichkeit*: the capacity to perceive clearly the state one is in, before attempting to transform or perform it.

My sensitivity to shifts in state also has a personal history: undiagnosed hallucinatory visual migraines and mild ecstatic seizures in my youth made changes in consciousness feel recognisable and familiar rather than abstract. I remember designing my own state exercises as early as fifteen. Later, in my search for meaningful movement in dance, I began a simple experiment: stopping intentional movement and waiting until movement arose on its own. What emerged was qualitatively different — slower and less controlled, but carrying a sense of necessity, of inner need, I had not encountered before. Alongside this shift in movement, there was a shift in perception: a state in which thoughts, emotions, and sensations felt less owned, more like phenomena passing through me.

This experience made clear that the quality of expression was not determined solely by technique or intention, but by the state from which it emerged — and that such states are not fixed, but can be entered, cultivated, and stabilised through practice. My later encounter with Mahamudra and psychophysical theatre did not introduce a foreign concern, but gave language, structure, and method to a territory I had already begun to recognise experientially.

The Social Contract

To music is to take part, in any capacity, in a musical performance, whether by performing, by listening, by rehearsing or practicing, by providing material for performance (what is called composing), or by dancing. ... For performance does not exist in order to present musical works, but rather, musical works exist in order to give performers something to perform.

Christopher Small, *Musicking*

What does it mean to participate in a musical performance in the contemporary West? One educational resource summarises the responsibilities of a great audience member as follows: arrive on time, be quiet, turn off your phone, sit upright (Hishon, 2017). This is, in essence, our official education in participation: a set of instructions oriented almost entirely toward minimising the audience's presence rather than cultivating it.

Christopher Small, in *Musicking*, invites us to approach the Western concert format as an ethnic music practice like any other — not as a neutral or inevitable arrangement, but as a culturally specific one that can be examined (Small, 1998). The concert format treats music as a work rather than an event: a fixed object to be delivered from composer to listener through the medium of the performer. Communication runs in one direction only. James Johnson shows that even the silence of the modern concert audience is a relatively recent invention, crystallised at a specific historical moment for specific cultural reasons (Johnson, 2008). What we have inherited is not a natural condition of listening. It is a choice that has stopped announcing itself as one.

This matters directly for the second research question: can a singer transform the relational field with an audience? Small's and Johnson's analyses suggest that the format itself actively constrains that field — it encodes a particular model of the performer-audience relation into the physical and social arrangement of the event. The singer who wishes to work with *Gestimmtheit* as relational attunement is working against a structural headwind. This research acknowledges the external dimensions — changes to concert format, setting, and the forms of participation available to the audience — as important, while delegating them to future research. Its immediate focus is on what can change from the inside: how a different quality of inner state and imaginal relation can shift the relational field even within a conventional format.

The Theatrical

If the Western concert format produces a certain distance between performer and audience, theatre makes this distance explicit. The performer is visibly constructing a situation, inhabiting a role, speaking words that are not their own. Theatre, more than music, has therefore been compelled to develop practices that address the question of genuine presence directly.

Michael Chekhov

Michael Chekhov's contribution to psychophysical performance is perhaps the most systematically developed in this lineage. Rather than working primarily with emotional

memory or psychological analysis (as is done in Method Acting), Chekhov developed what might be called a technology of imagination: a rigorous, trainable system in which the performer's imaginal life produces perceptible, real changes in the body, the voice, and what the performer radiates to those watching (Čechov, 1991). Through tools such as the psychological gesture — a physical action that encodes an inner quality or aesthetic orientation directly in the body — he offered performers a generative framework for entering into deep, playful relation with their material.

For this research, Chekhov's framework translates remarkably directly from actor to singer. The imaginal work, the psychological gesture, the capacity to radiate a quality rather than merely intend it — all have direct vocal applications and speak directly to the first and third research questions: can a singer relate differently to their voice, and through what practices? If you imagine singing on a barren planet, you sing differently than if you imagine singing in a dense jungle — and Chekhov's framework explains precisely why, and how to develop this capacity deliberately.

Where Chekhov becomes less useful, however, is in his treatment of the audience. His framework rests on an unstated assumption: that an inspired performance will naturally reach those who watch it. The audience is the destination of the performer's inner work, not a source of inspiration in its own right. The relationship between performer and audience is not treated as a field that can itself be entered, trained, and worked with. This is precisely the limitation that the second research question seeks to address: Chekhov gives us tools for the singer's inner relation to their voice, but not for the deliberate shaping of the relational field with an audience.

Antero Alli

Antero Alli is a paratheatre practitioner who approaches the same territory from a different angle. Where Chekhov develops tools for relating to the material, Alli is primarily concerned with the conditions that make any genuine inner work possible in the first place. His practice is built around what he calls ritual technologies — practical structures for entering, sustaining, and closing states of heightened attention and receptivity (Alli, 2020). Central to this is the no-form practice: a deliberately cultivated condition of emptiness and receptivity before images, impulses, movement, or voice are allowed to emerge. This is not simply a warm-up. It is a fundamental reorientation — a clearing of the inner field that Alli treats as the necessary precondition for anything genuine to arise.

Alli's framework is not designed for conventional performance contexts. His work takes place with consenting participants who have agreed to enter a transformative process together. And yet his core insight — that the quality of what emerges in performance is shaped in significant ways by the quality of the clearing that precedes it — suggests a practice that can be adapted beyond the paratheatrical context. A singer can enter a ritual relation to a performance, and to an audience, without the audience being formally informed of this. The ritual is an inner stance, not an agreed format.

This adaptation is significant for the second research question. Alli does not offer tools for relating differently to an audience within a conventional concert; but his ritual orientation, brought inward, suggests that the relational field can be prepared and entered from the singer's side alone. Whether this is sufficient — whether the singer's inner stance can genuinely alter what is shared between performer and audience — is one of the central questions this research is moving toward.

Authenticity and Horizons of Significance

"All means are sacred which are called for by the inner need. All means are sinful which obscure that inner need."

Wassily Kandinsky, *On the Spiritual in Art*

The third research question — how does a singer know what they genuinely need to sing, and how can that inner necessity be distinguished from habit, technique, or performed conviction? — is the most philosophically demanding of the three, and the one that the preceding sections have been quietly approaching. If state-work makes many forms of expression available, authenticity becomes less a question of self-expression than of orientation. The problem is not whether a state, sound, or gesture is real in some simple sense, but whether it belongs to a horizon of significance — whether it answers to something that matters within the performer's relation to the material, the voice, the audience, and the world in which the work takes place.

Charles Taylor's account of authenticity is useful here. In *The Ethics of Authenticity*, Taylor does not dismiss authenticity as a shallow modern value (Taylor, 1992). On the contrary, he recognises it as one of the defining moral ideals of modern life. What he questions is the reduced version in which being true to oneself becomes detached from any larger field of meaning. For Taylor, authenticity cannot be grounded in preference alone. It depends on horizons of significance: contexts of value within which some choices matter more than others.

For this research, Taylor's account has a direct implication. Access to many states — the result of the kind of training this research is building toward — does not by itself give direction. The singer may be able to enter different relations to their voice, may be able to shift the quality of their presence and attunement; but which of these is required by the work? This question cannot be answered by technique alone. Kandinsky's concept of *innere Notwendigkeit* names what Taylor's horizon of significance points toward in artistic terms: the pressure exerted by genuine need on artistic choice (Kandinsky, 1946). A means is sacred when it is called for; sinful when it obscures the call.

The question of inner necessity — how a performer knows what is genuinely required of them, as distinct from what they have learned to produce — has been approached most seriously not in vocal practice but in dance and theatre. Two traditions in particular are relevant here.

Authentic Movement, developed by Mary Whitehouse and later Janet Adler from a Jungian and somatic background, trains the capacity to wait for impulse to arise from genuine inner necessity rather than from intention or performance — to distinguish between what the body actually wants to do and what the performer decides to do (Adler, 2002).

Grotowski's *via negativa* approaches the same territory from the opposite direction. Rather than waiting for genuine impulse to arise, it works by elimination — systematically removing the habits, tensions, and falseness that prevent truthful expression from emerging (Grotowski, 1991). What remains, after that stripping away, is not a universal human essence but something deeply particular: the specific history, cultural memory, and lived experience carried in the body of the individual performer.

How these traditions apply concretely to the present research remains an open question. What they share — and what feels potentially significant — is an orientation of stripping away rather than adding: both work by removing what is false, habitual, or willed, rather than by cultivating new capacities. This is a different logic from the state-training and imaginal practices that form the current core of this research, and whether it is complementary or in tension with them is something that further engagement will need to explore.

Emerging Methodology

The practices that constitute this research do not yet form a fixed or closed system. They are better understood as an ecology — a set of interrelated approaches that inform and respond to one another, developed through daily engagement and refined through performance

experience. What follows is a preliminary account of the methodological directions emerging from the contextual work above, identifying the practices most relevant to each research question and the areas where further development is needed.

Clearing and attuning: toward the first research question

The first layer of the practice addresses the first research question directly: can a singer relate in different ways to their own voice, and if so, how? The starting point is a daily clearing — an attempt to arrive at a state in which I can sense myself clearly before anything else begins. This draws on Mahamudra practice and on Alli's no-form work, both of which train receptive lucidity: the capacity to let thoughts, sensations, emotions, and resistances appear without immediately acting on them.

Following this, I move into vocal training that is never purely technical. Because I arrive at it from a state of relative perceptual openness, I also learn from it — from how my body organises itself in reaching for different notes, from what resistance or ease arises, from what the voice reveals about the state I am in. The vocal practice is simultaneously instrument training and self-listening. Chekhov-style imagination exercises are brought into this work - for example singing while moving through different aesthetic orientations — ease, form, beauty — and noticing how each quality reorganises the voice from within.

Running through all of these practices is a strand of self-listening — an attempt to read the body's signals as diagnostic information. I have observed, for instance, that singing too loudly is often not a choice but a symptom — a compensation for a lack of conviction in the material. The recognition itself is significant: without it, inauthenticity passes unnoticed. I also listen to how language affects state — singing in Croatian and then in English produces noticeably different vocal and bodily organisations, and recording these differences has become a way of studying how *Befindlichkeit* shifts with linguistic and cultural context.

Preparing the relational field: toward the second research question

The second research question — can a singer learn to relate in different ways to their audience, transforming the relational field into artistic material? — is addressed through imaginal practices that alter my relation to the audience and to the material before performance begins. The most significant example so far has been a *retinue* practice drawn from a preparatory visualisation in my Mahamudra tradition: before one performance, I imagined the audience as a *retinue* — a gathering of presences who had come to offer blessings and support on a shared path. The performance that followed was, by any available measure, unusually connected: the audience response was more engaged than

usual, and the quality of contact felt — both from the inside and from what was reflected back — qualitatively different from performances where that imaginal preparation had been absent.

This is also where Alli's ritual thinking enters most directly. I approach the preparation for performance as a ritual — with a clear opening, a quality of intention, and a closing. The audience does not know this: the ritual is an inner orientation, not an agreed format. What it changes is the quality of attention and presence I bring to the encounter. Both Chekhov's imaginal framework and Alli's ritual structure are here being brought to bear on a dimension neither fully addresses: the deliberate shaping of the relational field from the inside.

Toward the third research question: inner necessity and the almost-ness practice

The third research question — how does a singer know what they genuinely need to sing? — is the most intuitive and least systematised area of the emerging practice. But one practice-event begins to approach it. During reflection after a performance, I noticed a quality I have come to call almost-ness: a state of being present enough to perform, but still slightly outside the action, monitoring it rather than entering it fully. From this observation emerged the mantra don't try — not as encouragement, but as a precise cut through a specific state. I began applying it in daily life first, training the shift from trying to not trying, from monitoring to being fully in it. Only once this shift had become somewhat reliable in ordinary contexts did I bring it into performance, where it produced an observable shift in the quality of presence and relation with the audience. The connection to inner necessity is this: almost-ness is a state in which the singer is managing rather than offering — present to the performance but not claimed by it. The mantra “don't try” is an attempt to locate the place from which genuine necessity speaks, by stepping out of the way of effortful control.

This cycle — a state perceived in reflection, investigated in daily life, developed into an intervention, tested under performance conditions — represents the methodological logic this research is developing. It is not systematic documentation at this stage; that rigour is identified as a primary task for the Investigate module. But it indicates the shape of a trainable practice: one in which Befindlichkeit is perceived clearly enough that Gestimmtheit — the fluid movement between states — becomes available as a deliberate artistic act.

Frankenstein: applications in composition

Working on the music for the theatre piece *Frankenstein* (Theater Vorpommern, Stralsund) — together with composer and theatre-maker Frieda Gawenda for the inclusive ensemble *Die Eckigen* — offered an unexpected test of how far this research had already changed something in my practice. The project involves composing original music for and with eleven performing artists who, while experienced as actors, had never used their singing voice in a performance context. Working with them, I found that what had developed in me was above all a capacity to listen differently: to hear in another person's voice what state they were in, what they were holding, what might become available if something shifted. Simpler versions of the state-work developed in this research — orienting singers toward ease, toward offering, toward imagining who they were singing for — produced noticeable shifts in vocal quality and expressive presence. What surprised me was how clearly I could perceive these shifts, and how directly I could name what I was hearing back to the singers in a way they could recognise and work with. The first research question — can a singer relate in different ways to their own voice? — turned out to have a pedagogical dimension I had not anticipated.

Future Directions

The next stage of this research moves in three interconnected directions.

The most immediate is a deeper engagement with Grotowski's *via negativa*. Having identified the question of inner necessity — how a singer knows what they genuinely need to sing — as the least formally developed area of the current practice, I intend to engage more systematically with Grotowski's process of elimination as a possible framework for what has so far been approached more intuitively.

A second direction is pedagogical and experimental. I am planning a series of workshops in which participants are guided through the stages of the practice developed in this research — from clearing and attuning, through vocal and imaginal work, to the question of authenticity and relational presence. These workshops will also function as a laboratory for the concert format itself: investigating what becomes possible when the social contract of performance is arranged differently, and a different quality of attention between singer and audience is built into the structure of the event.

A third direction is documentation and dissemination. Alongside the ongoing practice, I am working toward a small exercise booklet — a practical guide to the Method Singer framework that distils the core practices into a form that can be shared, tested, and refined by others.

Conclusion

This research began with a simple but persistent observation: that the quality of what passes between a singer and an audience is not fixed, not accidental, and not fully explained by technical accomplishment. Something else is at work — something that has to do with the state from which the singer sings, the quality of attention they bring, and the nature of the relation they are able to open with those who listen. The aim of this contextual review has been to map that territory: to find where it has been approached before, where it has been left unexplored, and what frameworks might be developed to engage it more deliberately.

The review has identified three research questions that together define the scope of this inquiry. The first concerns the singer's relation to their own voice — whether that relation can be developed, varied, and made more fluid. The second concerns the relational field between singer and audience — whether it can be deliberately shaped, and transformed into artistic material. The third, and perhaps most fundamental, concerns inner necessity: how a singer knows what they genuinely need to sing, and how that knowing can be distinguished from habit, technique, or performed conviction.

The traditions examined here — psychophysical theatre, paratheatrical practice, extended vocal work, contemplative practice — each address part of this territory with genuine rigour. None holds all of it together, and none seriously confronts the third question. This is where the present research situates itself: not outside these traditions, but in the space between them, drawing on each and extending beyond any one of them.

What this research is ultimately working toward is a particular kind of singer — one defined not by style or technique, but by a quality of presence and relation. A Method Singer is a performer who can inhabit whatever state they find themselves in, moving within it rather than fighting it, finding from inside it a genuine point of contact with an audience. They have the capacity to perceive their *Befindlichkeit* clearly enough that *Gestimmtheit* — fluid, responsive attunement — becomes available not as accident, but as art. And in doing so, they open the possibility of the kind of communion that this research has been, from the beginning, reaching toward.

This research is at an early stage, and much remains open. The next steps — a deeper engagement with Grotowski's *via negativa*, a series of workshops that will test the practice with others, and the ongoing development of a practical guide to the Method Singer

framework — are already partly in motion. What the contextual review has established is a clear direction: that the singer's inner state, their relation to their voice, and the field between them and their audience are not fixed conditions but trainable ones. That conviction is what this research is built on, and what the next stages will explore more deeply.

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